pillars (one of which had the same edicts as the one at Lauriya-Nandangarh) while towards the south, at Lauriya-Araraj, was located the site of another similarly inscribed pillar. These were routes that merchants and caravans continued to use into modern times. Such commercial connections also marked the sites of the pillar edicts in the Indo-Gangetic Doab. The significance of their geographical locations in relation to routes of communication has been highlighted in Chakrabarti's work on the Ashokan inscriptions. He points out that Meerut was on the straight route towards the Siwaliks in the area of modern Najibabad, from where a road went to Pauri via Kotdwar.[13] As for Topra, it was likely to have been on the direct line between Sirsawa and Ambala. Whether the Hissar and Fatehabad pillar segments were part of a monolith that was originally in the Hissar area, which shows early historic occupation, or from an important ancient site like Rohtak or Agroha in that area, remains unclear. An arterial route, though, used to pass through this region, to go towards Multan, eventually ending up in Afghanistan. This route was used well into the medieval era. Hissar town, historically known as Hisar-i Firuza, came to be founded by Firuz Shah partly because it was located on the old Delhi–Multan route which branched to Khorasan.[14]

Another kind of archive is arrived at from the hundreds of objects at ancient places along these routes. Their distant origins help in tracking the significance of lines of communication. Lapis lazuli beads originating from north Afghanistan are found in the entire axis from the Swat valley of Pakistan till the Burdwan district of Bengal, at places like Bir Kot Ghundai, Taxila, Sravasti, Rajghat, Prahladpur, and Pandu Rajar Dhibi.[15] Similarly, artefacts made of sea shell from the eastern coast were found in the middle Gangetic and the lower Gangetic plains, at places like Rajghat, Prahladpur, Vaishali, and Bangarh. That raw materials of various kinds moved across the Gangetic plains to reach the Nepal terai is evident from, among other things, the range of beads found at the ancient town of Tilaurakot.[16]